

Cultural Matching and the Persistence of Social Ties

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This paper develops and tests a cultural matching model of social tie persistence using longitudinal ego-network data from the NetSense study. We find that shared cultural tastes serve as a critical mechanism for stabilizing social ties, particularly for weaker relationships, while cultural network opacity—a lack of knowledge regarding an alter’s preferences—independently accelerates tie dissolution.

1 Introduction

A central puzzle in the sociology of culture and social networks is the co-evolution of social ties and cultural tastes (Lizardo, 2006; Edelman and Vaisey, 2014). Traditional sociological models of taste formation posit that an individual’s cultural profile is largely shaped by their current social network configuration (Mark, 1998b; McPherson, 2004). Tastes are assumed to diffuse through existing homophilous ties, which are themselves structured by socio-demographic similarity—“status homophily” (Lazarsfeld and Merton, 1954; McPherson et al., 2001; Feld and Grofman, 2009). Under this view, “birds of a feather flock together,” and, as a result, they end up consuming the same cultural goods (Mark, 2003). Tastes are construed as highly malleable, “thin” contents liable to shift whenever the surrounding network ties change. Yet longitudinal network research reveals that personal networks are in constant flux, with ties being added, modified, and deleted (Burt, 2000, 2002; Wellman et al., 1997; Ahmad et al., 2021). This empirical fact of network volatility raises a major question: if networks are unstable and tastes are merely thin, network-contingent contents, how do we account for the durable, resilient cultural profiles that individuals maintain over time (Bourdieu, 1984; Holt, 1998)?

In this paper, we develop and test a **cultural matching model** of tie persistence. We propose that, rather than tastes merely adapting to match pre-existing networks, pre-existing cultural dispositions serve as an active “social glue” that determines which network ties survive and which dissolve. Under this model, dyadic cultural matching (commonalities in tastes and activities) increases the over-time stability and cognitive salience of social ties, net of usual dyadic determinants such as subjective closeness and tie duration. Using rich longitudinal ego-network data from the *NetSense* study (Bahulkar et al., 2016, 2017; Hachen et al., 2022),

we track the persistence of social ties across multiple college-year transitions. To isolate peer dynamics, we focus on non-kin, on-campus student ties. We unpack this cultural matching mechanism in two ways. First, we establish the baseline protective effect of aggregate cultural matching on tie persistence. Second, we explore the role of “cultural network opacity”—the degree to which an ego lacks knowledge of their alter’s preferences (indicated by “Don’t Know” responses)—as an independent predictor of tie decay.

2 Theoretical Framework

2.1 Tastes and Social Networks: Two Perspectives

The relationship between cultural tastes and social networks has been conceptualized in two contrasting ways in sociological theory. The **network transmission perspective**, drawing on constructural imagery (Carley, 1991), views tastes as malleable, network-contingent contents (Erickson, 1988, 1996; Mark, 1998a, 2003). Recent work suggests that this malleability is constrained by deeper, latent cultural structures. In this view, social ties constitute the pre-existing “infrastructure” or “pipes” through which cultural practices diffuse (Borgatti, 2005; Erickson, 1996). Tastes are learned, adopted, and abandoned based on continuous exchange of cultural information and local bandwagon imitation within an actor’s immediate ego network (Mark, 2003). Because personal networks exhibit substantial over-time volatility—with 30% to 60% turnover annually in most personal networks (Morgan et al., 1997; Suitor et al., 1997)—the network transmission perspective implies that individual tastes must exhibit corresponding volatility.

In contrast, the **cultural capital perspective** conceptualizes tastes as highly durable, embodied dispositions reaped from early socialization (Bourdieu, 1984, 1990; Holt, 1997, 1998). Emphasizing the “interconvertibility” of different forms of capital (Bourdieu, 1986), this view sees cultural aptitudes not merely as by-products of ties, but as fundamental resources that help people form and sustain network connections. Here, networks are seen as fleeting structures built and maintained via interactions (DiMaggio, 1987). Consequently, individuals actively use pre-existing tastes to construct novel relationships or shed culturally incompatible ties, a dynamic formalized in the cultural matching model (Lizardo, 2006; Vaisey and Lizardo, 2010). In this framework, internalized cultural practices exert an independent causal effect in shaping social networks because people self-select into ties based on the match between their tastes and others’ (Shalizi and Thomas, 2011).

Building on this insight, recent theoretical elaborations specify how matching and influence operate simultaneously as dual mechanisms. For instance, Lewis and Kaufman (2018) propose a generalized conversion model demonstrating that cultural conversion (tastes diffusing through ties) and cultural matching (ties forming based on shared tastes) operate in tandem, constrained by the local cultural ecology. Crucially for our present study, the degree of cultural match at the dyadic level fundamentally determines whether relationships endure over time or instead selectively decay (Martin and Yeung, 2006). If tastes are durable and personal networks are volatile, it is highly probable that tastes serve as *drivers* of network connections rather than being exclusively determined by them. This leads to the concept of **choice homophily** or

cultural matching: new social connections are selected, and existing connections are maintained, based on pre-existing cultural compatibility (Lazarsfeld and Merton, 1954; Werner and Parmelee, 1979). In other words, socio-demographic homophily may frequently operate as a *by-product* of active contact selection keyed around cultural alignment, rather than homophily acting as an exogenous structural constraint (Carley, 1991; DiMaggio, 1987).

2.2 Cultural Matching and Tie Persistence

A major challenge for any newly formed social relationship is what Burt (Burt, 2000), drawing on Stinchcombe (1965), refers to as the “**liability of newness.**” Newly formed dyadic ties are fragile and exhibit a high baseline hazard of decay (“tie decay”), which steeply declines as a relationship matures and ripens into close friendship. What stabilizes a tie and helps it overcome this liability of newness? While classic network models emphasize structural factors (such as network constraint or multiplexity) and dyadic factors (such as subjective closeness), we propose that **cultural matching** serves as a vital stabilizing mechanism. Shared tastes and cultural practices provide a common cognitive and behavioral baseline that facilitates smooth, low-cost social interaction (Collins, 2004; DiMaggio, 1987).

When ego and alter share cultural dispositions, they can engage in shared activities and coordinate behavior with minimal friction. Over time, this cultural alignment increases the cognitive salience of the alter, rendering the tie resistant to decay and facilitating its retention in the ego’s active network (Burt, 2000). Therefore, we expect that commonalities in cultural tastes and leisure practices will significantly reduce the hazard of tie decay, net of subjective closeness and structural controls (**The Baseline Matching Hypothesis**).

If shared cultural knowledge stabilizes ties, then a *lack* of mutual cultural knowledge—*cultural network opacity*—is a diagnostic signal of relationship precarity. When an ego reports “Don’t Know” regarding an alter’s preferences across multiple cultural domains, this indicates a lack of conversational intimacy and shared experiences, which should independently predict a higher hazard of tie dissolution (Burt, 2002; Wellman et al., 1997). We test both the main effect of cultural network opacity on tie decay and whether opacity moderates the protective effect of known cultural matches.

Furthermore, recent research highlights two critical extensions to the cultural matching framework. First, building on the insight that tastes function as a “system of distinctions,” Edelman and Vaisey (2014) demonstrate that shared dislikes—the mutual non-consumption or rejection of cultural goods—are just as crucial for relationship development as shared likes. Accordingly, we distinguish between positive matches (shared likes) and negative matches (shared dislikes) to examine whether shared aversion similarly stabilizes ties. Second, Edelman and Vaisey (2014) emphasize that cultural matching may not matter equally across all types of relationships, finding that tastes are primarily associated with the maintenance of strong ties rather than weak or incidental connections. To test this boundary condition, we estimate interaction models to assess whether the protective effect of cultural matching is amplified among ties with higher subjective closeness.

3 Data and Methods

Data for this analysis comes from the NetSense study, a longitudinal survey of college students conducted at the University of Notre Dame between 2011 and 2015. The study collected extensive panel data on students’ social networks, demographic backgrounds, and cultural preferences. A comprehensive codebook, data dictionary, and repository for the NetSense project are available at <https://olizardo.github.io/NetSense-Codebook/>.

We collected information on the cultural habits of ego-alter pairs using both a series of closed-form domain questions and open-ended activity nominations. For the closed-form items, egos were asked to rate both their own and their alters’ level of interest across six broad cultural and leisure domains: music, movies, books, sports, games, and outdoor activities. For the open-ended items, respondents freely nominated up to five leisure activities they enjoyed, and then indicated whether their alter also engaged in each nominated activity.

3.1 Study Waves

The NetSense study is a longitudinal survey of college students collected over multiple waves. For this analysis of tie persistence, we pool data across adjacent waves to construct a person-period dataset. To isolate peer dynamics, we restrict our sample to non-kin, on-campus ties (i.e., alters who are also students at Notre Dame). To capture relationship dynamics across the entirety of the college experience, we construct a discrete-time person-period dataset spanning all available adjacent survey waves (Wave 1 through Wave 8). This design allows us to observe tie persistence continuously across varying intervals of the students’ academic careers, capturing both the initial network churn of freshman year and the consolidation of networks approaching graduation.

3.2 Measures

3.2.1 Dependent Variable

Tie Persistence: A binary indicator taking a value of 1 if a social tie reported by an ego in a baseline wave (e.g., Wave 1) is still present in the subsequent wave (e.g., Wave 2), and 0 if the tie has dissolved (i.e., the alter is no longer listed in the ego’s network). To determine tie presence, egos were asked to list the people with whom they interact most frequently, with the prompt: “Please list the people with whom you have spent the most time in the last month.” Egos could nominate up to 20 alters in each wave.

3.2.2 Independent Variables

- *Closed-Form Cultural Matching*: A count variable (ranging from 0 to 6) indicating the number of closed-form cultural domains in which the ego and alter share similar tastes. Egos were asked to rate their own interest and their alters’ interest across six broad domains: music, movies, books, sports, games, and outdoor activities. The specific survey prompt for egos was: “How interested are you in the following activities?” and for alters:

“How interested is this person in the following activities?” Response categories included “Very interested,” “Somewhat interested,” and “Not at all interested.” A domain was scored as a “match” if the ego rated both themselves and their alter identically.

- *Open-Ended Activity Matching*: A count variable (ranging from 0 to 5) capturing the number of shared specific activity nominations. Egos were asked to freely list up to five leisure activities they enjoyed with the prompt: “Please list up to 5 specific activities that you enjoy doing in your free time.” Subsequently, for each alter, the ego was asked to check boxes indicating which of these specific activities the alter also enjoyed, prompted with: “Which of your favorite activities does this person also enjoy?”
- *Cultural cultural network opacity*: A count variable (ranging from 0 to 6) measuring the number of cultural domains for which the ego responded “Don’t know” regarding their alter’s preferences. For the closed-form domain questions regarding alters (“How interested is this person in the following activities?”), respondents were provided a fourth response category: “Don’t know.” This variable sums the number of domains where this option was selected.

3.2.3 Control Variables

- *Subjective Closeness*: Measured with the prompt, “How close are you to this person?” Response categories were “Not close” (1), “Somewhat close” (2), and “Very close” (3). This is treated as a factor variable in the models.
- *Relationship Type*: Derived from the prompt “How are you connected to this person?” We include binary indicators for whether the tie is a **Friend** (vs. other types) or a **Roommate/Dormmate** (capturing on-campus structural proximity).
- *Frequency of Interaction*: Measured with the prompt, “How often do you communicate with this person?” Responses were dichotomized into a **High Frequency** indicator (**Daily** or **Weekly**) versus the reference category (**Monthly** or **Less often**).
- *Tie Duration*: A continuous measure of how long the ego has known the alter (in years), asked via “How long have you known this person?” We include both the linear and squared terms (*Duration Squared*) to account for nonlinearities in the liability of newness.
- *Demographics*: We control for ego gender and alter gender (1 = Woman, 0 = Man), along with a multiplicative interaction term to capture same-gender vs. cross-gender dynamics. We also include a measure of *Race Homophily*, constructed by matching self-reported race for the ego and self-reported race for the alter. Ties are classified as **Homophilous** (same race), **Heterophilous** (different race), or **Unknown** (if either ego or alter race was missing).
- *Time Period*: Dummy variables for each wave transition interval (Wave 1 to 2, Wave 2 to 3, Wave 3 to 4, Wave 4 to 5, Wave 5 to 6, Wave 6 to 7, Wave 7 to 8) to allow the baseline hazard of tie persistence to vary across the entire panel span.

3.3 Analytical Strategy and Model Specification

Because our data tracks relationships over time and individuals can nominate multiple alters, our data structure consists of dyad-periods nested within egos. To properly analyze tie persistence and account for right-censoring, we employ a discrete-time survival analysis framework (event history modeling). Since the outcome variable—whether a tie persists into the next wave—is binary, we estimate the hazard of tie survival using mixed-effects logistic regression.

To address the non-independence of observations arising from the clustered nature of the ego-network data (multiple ties per ego), we include random intercepts for egos. This accounts for unobserved, time-invariant individual heterogeneity in the baseline propensity to maintain ties.

The models take the following general form:

$$\text{logit}(P(Y_{ijt} = 1)) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_{ijt} + \beta_2 C_{ijt} + u_i \quad (1)$$

where Y_{ijt} is the indicator of tie persistence for ego i and alter j at time t , X_{ijt} represents the vector of our core theoretical predictors (cultural matching and cultural network opacity), C_{ijt} is a vector of dyadic and structural control variables (including time period indicators to allow the baseline hazard to vary), and u_i is the ego-specific random intercept, assumed to be normally distributed with mean zero.

All models are estimated via maximum likelihood using the `glmer` function from the `lme4` package in R, utilizing the BOBYQA optimizer to ensure model convergence. In models interacting subjective closeness with our cultural variables, we calculate and plot average marginal effects to facilitate interpretation of the non-linear interaction terms.

To ensure the robustness of our core findings, we conduct several supplementary analyses. First, we substitute our mixed-effects modeling framework for an ego fixed-effects framework using conditional logistic regression (`survival::clogit`), which perfectly controls for all unobserved, time-invariant ego characteristics. We also test alternative link functions (probit and complementary log-log) to verify our results are not an artifact of the logistic functional form. Finally, following Erickson (Erickson, 1996), we reconstruct our closed-form matching variable to differentiate between shared “likes” and shared “dislikes” to test whether cultural boundary-drawing operates symmetrically.

For a full summary of descriptive statistics, see Tables 2 and 3 in the Appendix.

4 Results

Our analysis proceeds in two stages. First, we examine the main effects of cultural matching and cultural network opacity on the likelihood of tie persistence, holding dyadic and structural factors constant. Second, we explore how the role of cultural matching and cultural network opacity varies across different levels of baseline tie strength (subjective closeness).

4.1 Main Effects: Cultural Matching and cultural network opacity

Table 1 presents the odds ratios from a series of mixed-effects logistic regression models predicting tie survival. Model 1 establishes our baseline, demonstrating that **closed-form cultural matching** significantly increases the odds of tie persistence. For each additional broad cultural domain (e.g., music, movies, sports) in which an ego and alter share tastes, the tie is substantially more likely to survive into the subsequent wave, net of controls for subjective closeness, tie duration, frequency of interaction, and demographic homophily.

In Model 2, we introduce **open-ended activity matches**. The inclusion of this variable demonstrates that specific, shared behavioral practices (such as co-participating in a particular hobby or sport) provide additive protective value above and beyond broad categorical taste similarities. Both closed-form and open-ended matching independently reduce the hazard of tie decay.

Model 3 tests the independent effect of **cultural network opacity**—measured as the number of domains in which the ego reported “Don’t Know” regarding their alter’s preferences. As expected, cultural network opacity is a strong negative predictor of tie persistence. A lack of mutual cultural knowledge signals a lack of conversational intimacy; as the number of “unknown” domains increases, the likelihood of tie survival sharply drops.

To contextualize these coefficients, Figure 1 displays the average marginal effects of moving from the minimum to the maximum observed values for each of our core theoretical variables. Across the board, cultural matching serves as a robust protective mechanism against tie decay, whereas cultural network opacity acts as a profound liability.

4.2 The Moderating Role of Subjective Closeness

While the main effects demonstrate that cultural alignment generally stabilizes ties, we next assess whether this “social glue” is uniformly necessary for all relationships. We estimated auxiliary interaction models (not shown in tables, but visualized via marginal effects) to test whether the protective effects of cultural matching and the detrimental effects of cultural network opacity are moderated by baseline subjective closeness.

Because interaction terms in logistic models can be opaque due to the non-linear link function, Figure 2 plots the predicted average marginal effect of our three cultural variables across ties rated as “Not Close,” “Somewhat Close,” and “Close.”

The results reveal a striking asymmetry: the role of cultural matching and opacity is highly dependent on tie strength. Counter to a “liability of newness” scaffolding hypothesis, we find that the marginal effects are steepest and most significant for *strong* ties (those rated “Close”). For these relationships, an increase in shared cultural tastes dramatically increases the probability of tie persistence. Conversely, for weak ties (those rated “Not Close”), the marginal effect slopes are essentially flat and not statistically differentiable from zero.

This interaction suggests that shared cultural tastes are less about providing superficial scaffolding for fragile new ties, and more about serving as the substantive “core” of deep, institutionalized friendships. Close friendships require ongoing, intensive cultural alignment to be maintained, rendering them highly sensitive to both matching and opacity. Weak ties,

on the other hand, are fleeting and superficial; their baseline hazard of decay is so high that cultural matching does little to save them.

4.3 Robustness Checks and Supplementary Analyses

To confirm that our findings are not artifacts of our primary model specifications, we estimated a series of robustness checks (detailed in Appendix B).

First, we estimated an **Ego Fixed-Effects model** via conditional logistic regression. By stratifying the likelihood function by ego, this approach leverages only within-ego variance—comparing the alters a single ego retains versus the alters that same ego drops. This stringent test perfectly isolates dyadic tie characteristics from unobserved individual baseline differences (such as an ego’s baseline sociability, introversion, or general propensity to drop ties). Across these fixed-effects models, closed-form matches, open-ended matches, and cultural network opacity all retained their significance and directional effects, confirming that the cultural matching dynamic operates primarily at the dyadic level.

Second, we tested alternative functional forms, re-estimating the baseline models using **probit** and **complementary log-log (cloglog)** link functions. The cloglog link is particularly well-suited for discrete-time survival analysis of asymmetric, rare events. The results were functionally identical to the standard logistic estimates.

Finally, we explored the valence of cultural matching by disaggregating closed-form matches into **shared likes** (both ego and alter express interest in a domain) versus **shared dislikes** (both ego and alter indicate they are “Not at all interested”). Consistent with theories of cultural boundary-drawing (Erickson, 1996), we found that shared dislikes are just as protective against tie decay as shared likes. This demonstrates that bonding over a mutual aversion to a cultural domain provides equivalent structural scaffolding for a social relationship as shared consumption.

5 Discussion and Conclusion

5.1 Summary of Key Findings

In this paper, we sought to address a central puzzle in the sociology of culture and social networks: how do cultural tastes shape the evolutionary dynamics of personal networks? Using longitudinal ego-network data from the NetSense study, we tested a cultural matching model of tie persistence. Our results provide robust evidence that shared cultural tastes are a vital mechanism for stabilizing social ties. Specifically, both broad, closed-form cultural matches and specific, open-ended activity matches independently reduce the hazard of tie dissolution. Furthermore, we identified cultural network opacity—the lack of mutual cultural knowledge—as a powerful, independent liability that accelerates tie decay. Crucially, the protective effect of cultural matching and the detrimental effect of cultural network opacity are heavily concentrated among strong ties. For subjectively close ties, cultural alignment forms the core basis of relationship maintenance, whereas weak ties appear too fleeting to be rescued by taste homophily alone.

5.2 Theoretical and Substantive Interpretations

These findings carry significant theoretical implications for how we understand the relationship between tastes and networks. The results challenge the assumption of the pure network transmission perspective, which treats cultural tastes merely as fluid by-products of existing social ties (Mark, 2003). Instead, our findings align more closely with the cultural capital perspective (Bourdieu, 1984; Vaisey and Lizardo, 2010), suggesting that tastes function as durable, portable resources that individuals actively use to select, maintain, and discard social relationships.

We conceive of cultural matching as an essential structural core of close relationships. While early network theories emphasized structural constraints or multiplexity (Burt, 2000), our findings suggest that shared tastes are what give dense relationships their staying power. In the absence of mutual cultural knowledge (high opacity), even subjectively close ties face a high hazard of dissolution. This developmental view of networks helps reconcile the volatility of personal networks with the relative stability of individual cultural profiles: people churn through weak ties at a high baseline rate, but they use their stable cultural compass to actively maintain the core relationships that matter.

5.3 Limitations and Future Research

Despite these robust findings, several limitations point toward fruitful avenues for future research. First, our empirical focus on a sample of college students at a single university limits the generalizability of our claims. The college transition is a period of heightened network flux and identity formation. Future research should examine whether cultural matching operates similarly as a stabilizing force in adult populations, workplace settings, or among older adults where network dynamics and the salience of different cultural domains may differ.

Second, our current operationalization treats most cultural matches as theoretically equivalent. While our robustness checks demonstrated that shared dislikes operate similarly to shared likes, future research could further disaggregate these domains to test whether high-status cultural matches (e.g., classical music, literature) confer different relational advantages compared to popular or low-status domains (DiMaggio, 1987).

Finally, while our discrete-time survival framework effectively models tie decay, future studies would benefit from deploying stochastic actor-oriented models (SAOMs) to simultaneously model tie creation, tie dissolution, and individual taste change. Such an approach could fully disentangle the reciprocal processes of network-based cultural influence and culture-based social selection.

Figures

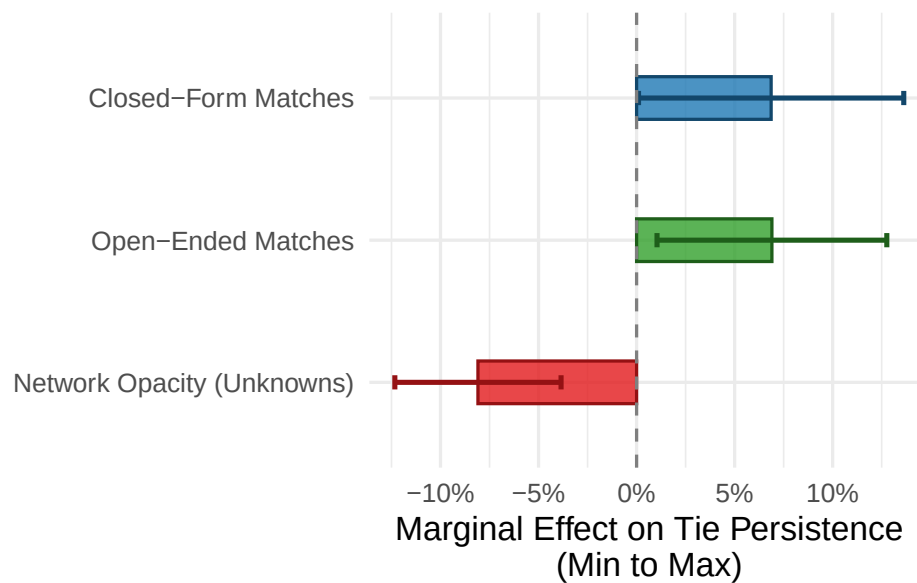


Figure 1: Marginal Effects of Cultural Matching and cultural network opacity on Tie Persistence.
 Note: Estimates represent the average marginal effect on the probability of tie persistence.

Tables

Table 1: Odds Ratios for Tie Persistence (Main Effects Models)

	Model 1: Closed	Model 2: + Open	Model 3: + Opacity
Closed-Form Matches	1.089** (0.035)	1.076* (0.035)	
Open-Ended Matches		1.084** (0.034)	1.088** (0.034)
Network Opacity			0.933+ (0.034)
Subjective Closeness: Somewhat	1.406* (0.188)	1.351* (0.182)	1.324* (0.179)
Subjective Closeness: Close	2.426*** (0.344)	2.271*** (0.327)	2.211*** (0.323)
Tie Duration (Years)	0.991 (0.044)	0.988 (0.043)	0.987 (0.043)
Tie Duration Squared	1.002 (0.002)	1.002 (0.002)	1.002 (0.002)
Ego: Woman	1.079 (0.157)	1.050 (0.154)	1.052 (0.155)
Alter: Woman	1.102 (0.114)	1.062 (0.111)	1.066 (0.112)
Ego Woman $\times$ Alter Woman	0.815 (0.130)	0.849 (0.136)	0.847 (0.135)
Roommate/Dormmate	0.797 (0.129)	0.804 (0.130)	0.802 (0.129)
Frequency: Weekly/Daily	2.131** (0.522)	2.142** (0.525)	2.273*** (0.558)
Race Homophily: Same Race	0.951 (0.121)	0.945 (0.120)	0.936 (0.119)
Race Homophily: Unknown	0.232*** (0.029)	0.230*** (0.029)	0.227*** (0.029)
Time Period: Wave 2-3	0.456*** (0.057)	0.463*** (0.058)	0.486*** (0.061)
Time Period: Wave 3-4	0.536*** (0.082)	0.525*** (0.081)	0.441*** (0.063)
Time Period: Wave 4-5	2.806*** (0.363)	2.824*** (0.366)	2.800*** (0.362)
Time Period: Wave 5-6	2.022*** (0.240)	2.019*** (0.240)	2.003*** (0.238)
Num.Obs.	5497	5497	5497
AIC	5256.6	5251.7	5253.3
BIC	5375.6	5377.3	5378.9

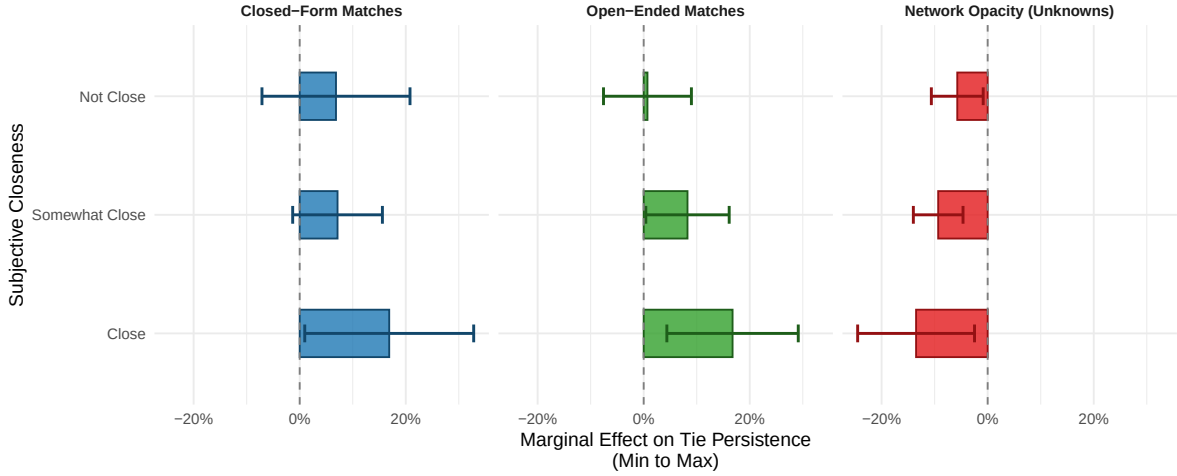


Figure 2: Marginal Effects of Cultural Matching and cultural network opacity on Tie Persistence by Subjective Closeness. Note: Estimates represent the average marginal effect on the probability of tie persistence.

A Appendix: Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics for all continuous and categorical variables used in the discrete-time survival analysis models.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics (Continuous)

	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Closed-Form Matches	1.56	1.50	0.00	6.00
Open-Ended Matches	2.48	1.35	0.00	5.00
Cultural Network Opacity	0.52	1.23	0.00	6.00
Tie Duration (Years)	3.98	6.00	0.00	21.16

B Appendix: Robustness Checks

To ensure the robustness of our core findings, we estimated several alternative model specifications, the results of which are dynamically rendered in the supplementary tables.

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics (Categorical)

		N	Percent
Tie Persisted	0	4311	70.18
	1	1832	29.82
Ego Gender	Men	3007	48.95
	Women	2569	41.82
Alter Gender	Men	3131	50.97
	Women	2991	48.69
Subjective Closeness	Not Close	681	11.09
	Somewhat Close	2890	47.05
	Close	2504	40.76
Interaction Frequency	Daily	184	3.00
	Less often	5933	96.58
	Weekly	26	0.42
Race Homophily	Heterophilous	624	10.16
	Homophilous	1786	29.07
	Unknown	3733	60.77

B.1 Alternative Specifications

We test an **Ego Fixed-Effects** model (conditional logistic regression via `survival::clogit`), which perfectly controls for unobserved time-invariant ego characteristics. We also test alternative link functions (**Probit** and **Cloglog**) to verify our results are not artifacts of the logistic functional form (see Table 4).

Table 4: Robustness Checks: Ego Fixed-Effects and Alternative Links

	Ego FE (clogit)	Probit	Cloglog
Closed-Form Matches	1.065+ (0.037)	0.033+ (0.019)	0.054* (0.026)
Open-Ended Matches	1.112*** (0.035)	0.047** (0.018)	0.058* (0.024)
Network Opacity	0.909* (0.034)	−0.030 (0.022)	−0.048 (0.030)
Num.Obs.	6054	5497	5497
AIC	5030.1	5262.8	5230.2
BIC	5144.2	5395.1	5362.4

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

B.2 Shared Likes vs. Shared Dislikes

We reconstruct the closed-form matching variable to differentiate between positive matches (both ego and alter express interest) and negative matches (both ego and alter indicate they are "Not at all interested"). Results (Table 5) indicate that shared dislikes are just as protective against tie decay as shared likes, supporting a boundary-drawing mechanism.

Table 5: Robustness Check: Shared Likes vs. Shared Dislikes

Shared Likes & Dislikes	
Shared Likes	1.069 (0.049)
Shared Dislikes	0.990 (0.099)
Open-Ended Matches	1.098* (0.040)
Network Opacity	0.950 (0.038)
Num.Obs.	3878
AIC	3933.8
BIC	4065.3
+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001	

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